

CHAPTER 6

# ORACLES



# SEEKING INSPIRATION

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In *Ironsworn*, an oracle is anything which generates random results to help determine the outcome of a move, a detail in your world, an NPC action, or a narrative event.

Among the choices provided in the *Ask the Oracle* move is “spark an idea” (page 108). You can use this option (instead of or in addition to the yes/no table) to answer open-ended questions or inspire new situations.

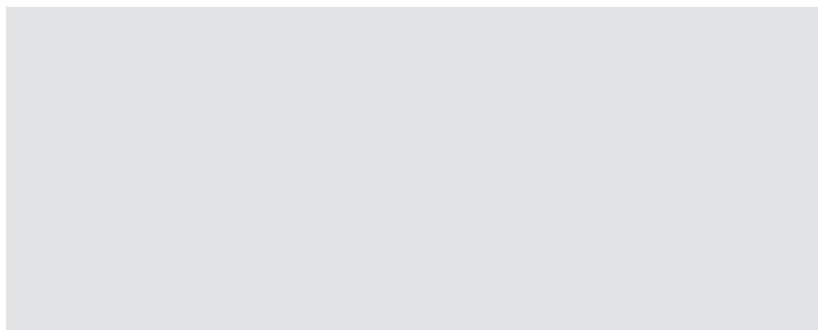
Rolling a match on a move (page 9) can also trigger opportunities to introduce narrative complications and surprises through random prompts.

This chapter includes a series of random prompts in the form of tables. You can use these oracle tables to answer questions about your world, drive the narrative, and inspire dramatic events and revelations. Some oracles are for specific, mundane questions to streamline play (“What is the healer’s name?”). Others provide more abstract results which you interpret based on the current situation (“What happens next?”).

## ORACLES IN SOLO AND CO-OP PLAY

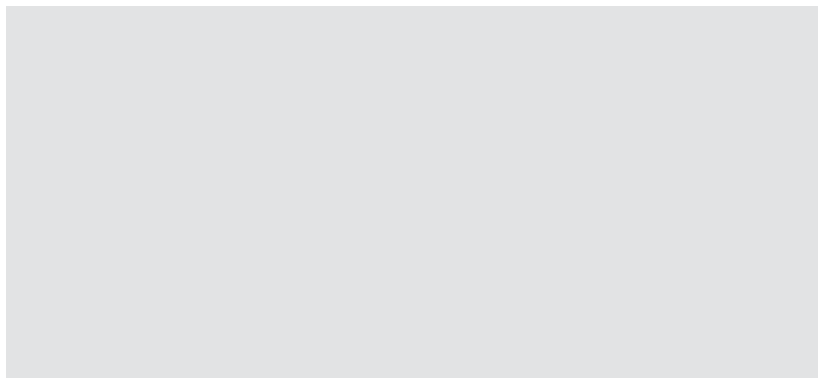
*Ironsworn* oracles don’t function as a GM simulator. Instead, they leverage the power of your creative interpretation. Ask your question, roll on a table, and consider the answer in the context of your current situation and story. What comes to mind first? Did you think of something which reinforces a dramatic narrative or takes things in an interesting and surprising direction? Does it feel right? If so, make it happen.

If you follow your instincts while staying open to twists and turns, you will find your game offering many of the same narrative rewards as if you were playing with a GM. In fact, you’ll be surprised how often a seemingly random result seems to feed directly into your character’s story and the world you’ve established through play. This is the power of creative interpretation at work.



## ORACLES IN GUIDED PLAY

GM's can use oracles for support during play and to supplement their narrative decision-making. Mundane oracles, such as names (page 184), are helpful to quickly flesh out details. Interpretative oracles, such as the Action and Theme tables (page 174), can be used to spark new ideas.



You can also use oracles as a prompt for sharing control of the narrative with your players. Not sure what happens next? Not sure how to answer a character's question? Roll on an appropriate table, or have a player make the roll, and talk it out with everyone at the table.



# IRONLAND ORACLES

## HOW TO USE THE TABLES



Ask your question and choose an appropriate oracle table.



Roll your oracle dice (page 22) to generate a number from 1-100.



Check your roll against the table. The oracle will reveal its answer.



Consider the answer in the context of your question and the current situation. Is the result a good fit? Does it trigger a spark of inspiration?



If the answer is difficult to interpret for your situation, you can check up or down one row from your original answer, or reverse the digits (37=73).



If you've got your answer, you're all set! Play to see what happens. If you want further detail, you can talk it out with other players or roll on another oracle table.

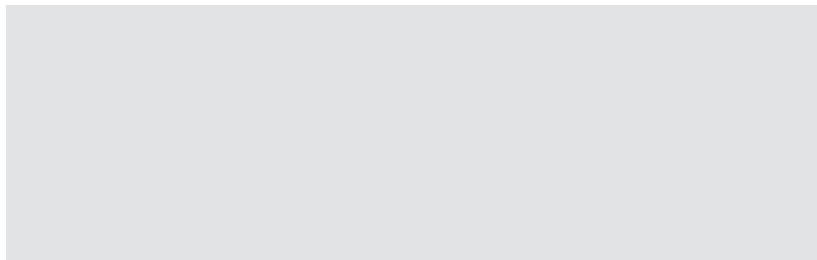


If you're having trouble, you can roll again, try a different table, or just fall back to your instincts and decide what happens next.

## WHEN ANSWERS LEAD TO MORE QUESTIONS

You aren't limited to a single roll on a single oracle table when asking a question. If you like, you can let the result from one table inform your interpretation of the result on another. You can even refer back to the *Ask the Oracle* table (page 107) to clarify an answer with a yes/no question.

However, use caution with this technique. Too many questions and too many rolls makes your session feel like an exercise in randomness. Lead with your instincts. Leverage the oracles to fill in the gaps. Keep it moving.



## ORACLE TABLES AND MATCHES

Matches don't have special significance when rolling on these oracle tables. They can be ignored.

## INTRO TO THE ORACLES

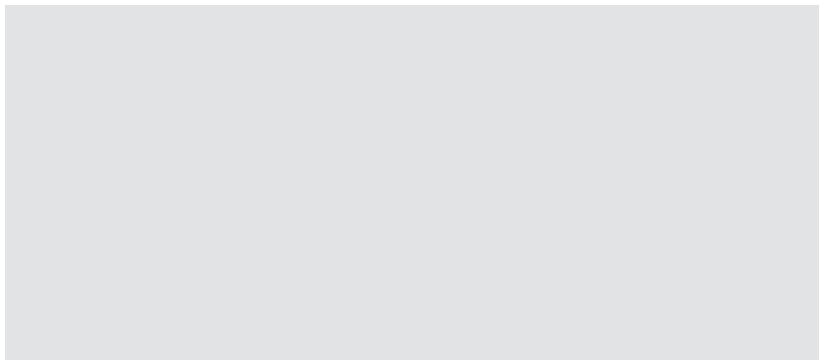
This chapter includes a variety of oracle tables. Use them in whatever way best fits your preferences and the needs of your story, but here's some basic recommendations.

### ORACLE 1: ACTION (PAGE 174)

Use this table to inspire a discovery, event, character goal, or situation. A roll on this table can be combined with a Theme (see below) to provide an action and a subject. Then, interpret the result based on the context of the question and your current situation.

### ORACLE 2: THEME (PAGE 175)

As with the Action oracle, this is an interpretative table which you can use to answer questions or generate new situations. Combined, the Action and Theme tables provide creative prompts suitable for most situations and questions. In fact, with some creative interpretations, it's entirely possible to play with only these two tables.



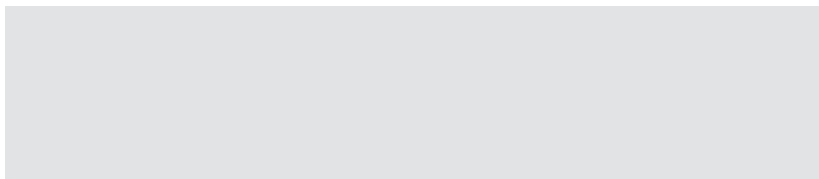
### **ORACLE 3: REGION (PAGE 176)**

Use this oracle when you want to randomly select a region with the Ironlands.

### **ORACLE 4: LOCATION (PAGE 176)**

Use this oracle when traveling to generate a point-of-interest or to answer a question about a place where someone or something can be found.

Your roll may generate a place or geographical feature which doesn't make sense in the context of your current location. If so, follow the guidelines on page 167 to generate a different result (look at adjacent rows or reverse the digits). Or, play off the original answer to introduce something unexpected.

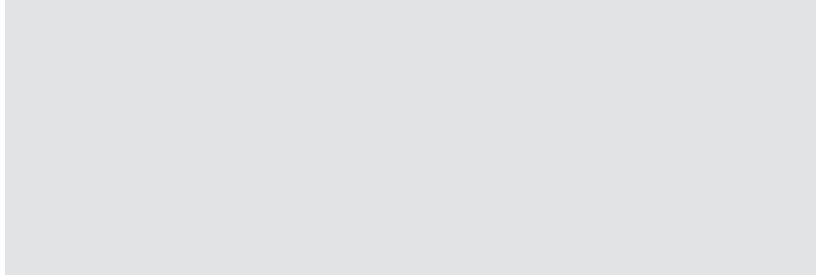


### **ORACLE 5: COASTAL WATERS LOCATION (PAGE 176)**

Use this oracle to identify a point-of-interest or destination when you are traveling by ship or boat along the coast.

### **ORACLE 6: LOCATION DESCRIPTION (PAGE 177)**

Use this oracle to add detail to the Location or Coastal Waters Location oracles, or by itself to generate a description of a location. Roll more than once for extra detail.



### **ORACLE 7: SETTLEMENT NAME (PAGE 178)**

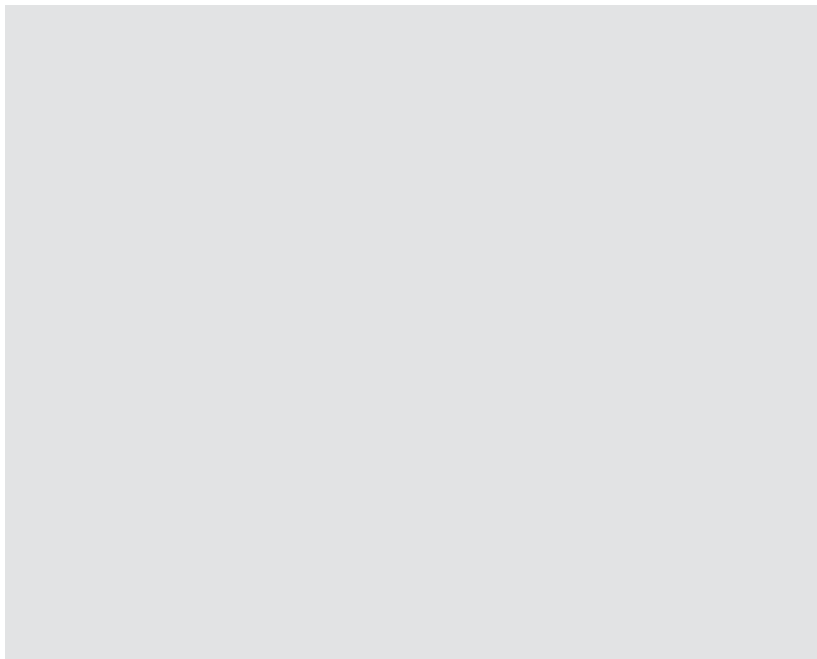
Ask this oracle for a thematic name for an Ironlander settlement. Roll once for the category, and again to pick from the examples. Alternatively, just roll for the category and come up with a name that fits the theme. In either case, consider the meaning of the name and how it impacts this settlement's surroundings, livelihood, culture, or history. This may, in turn, inspire narrative hooks and opportunities for new quests.

### **ORACLE 8: QUICK SETTLEMENT NAME GENERATOR (PAGE 180)**

Use this oracle as a simpler alternative for settlement names. Roll once for the prefix, and once for the suffix. If the combination doesn't quite work, look at adjacent rows or reverse the digits. Once you have your answer, envision what feature, person, or event inspired the name.

### **ORACLE 9: SETTLEMENT TROUBLE (PAGE 181)**

Use this table to generate a narrative hook for a problem faced by a community. This oracle can help inspire a vow for your character or serve as a prompt for a trouble you encounter when you interact with a settlement. Use other oracles, as appropriate, to help flesh out the answer.



### **ORACLE 10: CHARACTER ROLE (PAGE 182)**

Use this oracle to define the background for a character, or to generate a random encounter.

### **ORACLE 11: CHARACTER GOAL (PAGE 182)**

Use this oracle to define the primary motivation of an NPC or a faction. It can also be used to kick-off a personal quest for your own character.

### **ORACLE 12: CHARACTER DESCRIPTOR (PAGE 183)**

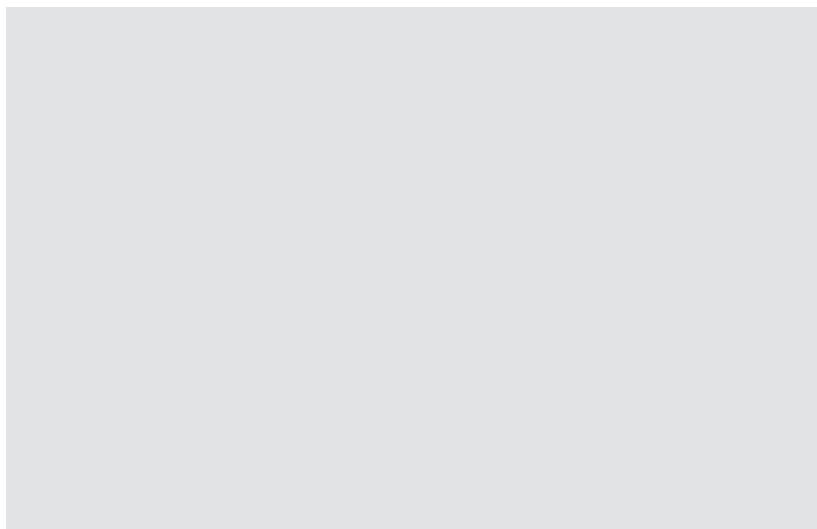
Use this oracle to help flesh out a character's personality or physical characteristics. Roll more than once to add additional detail. You can combine all three character oracles (10, 11 and 12), plus a roll on an appropriate name table, to build an outline of an NPC.



### **ORACLE 13: IRONLANDER NAMES (PAGE 184)**

Use this oracle to quickly generate a name for an Ironlander character. Roll on either table. Surnames are not used in the Ironlands and names are often gender-neutral. If a name doesn't fit a character, or you don't like the sound of it, look up or down a row for your answer, or reverse the digits.

You can also ignore this oracle and use your own preferred naming conventions or name generators for your Ironland characters.



### **ORACLE 14: ELF NAMES (PAGE 186)**

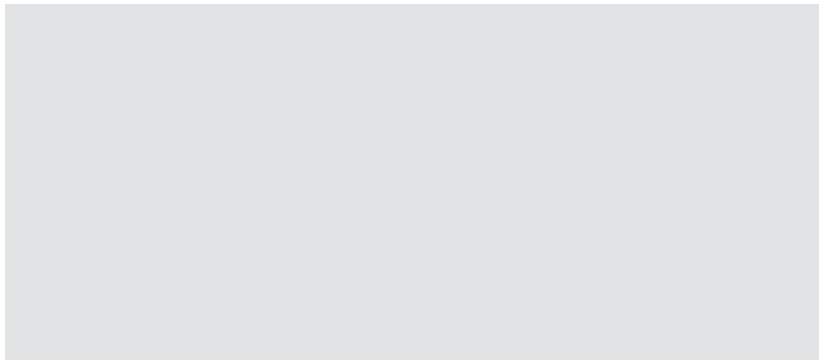
Use this oracle to generate a name for an elf character. To learn more about elves in the Ironlands, see page 142.

### **ORACLE 15: OTHER NAMES (PAGE 187)**

Use this oracle for other firstborn characters, including giants, varou, and trolls.

### **ORACLE 16: COMBAT ACTION (PAGE 188)**

Use this oracle to help inspire an action for an NPC in combat. When you're not sure what your foe does next, particularly when they have initiative, roll on this table and interpret the result as appropriate to your foe and the situation.



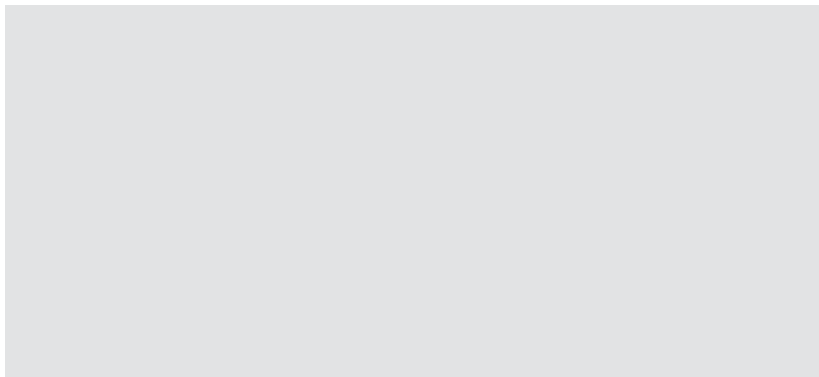
### **ORACLE 17: MYSTIC BACKLASH (PAGE 189)**

Those who deal in magic may find themselves at the mercy of chaos. This oracle can supplement, or replace, the *Pay the Price* table (page 105) when resolving the outcome of a failed ritual or other negative interaction with mystical forces. Use this oracle in dramatic moments, or to introduce an unexpected outcome triggered by a match.

### **ORACLE 18: MAJOR PLOT TWIST (PAGE 190)**

Use this oracle to introduce a narrative surprise or revelation. Most of these results have a negative implication, and can be used to resolve a match at a crucial moment in your story. In particular, this is an effective tool to leverage when you make a move with matched 10's on the challenge dice.

This oracle offers similar results to the *Pay the Price* table (page 105), but is more focused on dramatic events tied to your current quests.



### **ORACLE 19: CHALLENGE RANK (PAGE 190)**

Use this oracle when you want to randomly determine the challenge rank of a quest, journey, or fight.